

CAMP H O R



DAVID SHAW
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C A M P H O R

AMUSE BOUCHE

Gougère Pâte à Choux
with Black Truffle Cream and Comté Cheese Medallion

BEEF TARTARE

Classic Lemon Vinaigrette, Mustard, Black Pepper, Caper
Served with Basil and Mint Tempura

SCALLOP

Bay Scallops Wrapped in Demi Lune Pasta
Served with a Black Truffle and Chive Beurre Blanc Sauce

PITHIVIER

Mushroom Pithivier Layered with Portobello and Truffle Duxelle
Served with a Madeira Sauce

CHICKEN

Agrodolce Sauce

ASPARAGUS

Steam and Served with Béarnaise Sauce

KIWI

Kiwi Cubes Poached in Cardamom Syrup, Kiwi Jelly, Mint Ice Cream
Frozen Disc of Green Apple, Lemon Balm Tea, Charcoal Powder, and Coconut Milk

MIGNARDISE

Miniature Madeleines



It has been more than three years since my last visit to Camphor. I remember the beef tartare fondly, though at the time the restaurant did not entirely convince me of its stature as a serious fine-dining destination. While planning this return, I am struck by how little the menu has changed. Nearly every signature remains intact. What has shifted, however, is the pricing. Costs have climbed sharply since my previous visit, mirroring broader inflationary pressures and mounting strains within the hospitality industry. The once-celebrated chicken dish, which previously occupied the specialty category, has been folded into the standard entrées. The current specialties — Dover sole, ribeye, lobster saffron risotto, and a newly introduced mushroom pithivier — command formidable premiums. Most hover at or above \$150, with the lobster risotto reaching as high as \$220, despite arriving in a portion that feels rather restrained.

The pithivier in particular catches my attention, not only because of the rather reasonable price of \$48 but also due to my fondness for this pastry. I have long admired the form, ever since Maison Nico in San Francisco set a memorable benchmark for me, and I hope to share that experience with Serena. I reserve one in advance of our visit. At the table, I return to the beef tartare, the chicken, and the kiwi dessert, while adding a few new selections: a plate of asparagus and demi-lune ravioli filled with scallop.

As we finish ordering, an amuse-bouche is soon presented. The amuse-bouche stands as a perfect reflection of Camphor's ambiguous positioning. In the context of a restaurant that prices itself at fine-dining levels, such a gesture feels almost expected. Yet viewed through the lens of a polished bistro, which the menu format and ambience arguably suggest, the offering reads as a generous opening note. Described by the chef as a "light starter," the bite lands with more weight than the phrase implies. The gougère, crowned with a Comté medallion and black truffle cream, leans decisively toward richness. Still, it is a pleasure: layered in texture, from the firmness of the aged cheese to the supple creaminess beneath and the airy resilience of the choux. The black truffle struggles to shine through the heavy cheese duo, yet the overall effect remains indulgent and deeply savory.



The pacing at Camphor proves efficient. Without much delay, the familiar beef tartare returns. The portion is modest, composed of neatly cut cubes of raw beef dressed in a classic lemon vinaigrette with mustard, black pepper, and capers. The mustard lends a firm heat to the beef, a kind that is more rounded and lingering than aggressively sharp. Capers and vinaigrette bring welcome brightness, lifting the richness of the beef and allowing the dish to feel both substantial and refreshing, well-suited to Los Angeles's temperate climate. Tempura chips of basil and mint are offered as a creative flourish. In practice, however, the execution feels absurd. While a few larger leaves provide satisfying contrast, many of the smaller pieces make the dining process rather awkward and tedious, as I find myself repeatedly scooping a pathetically small amount of beef onto the chips. More importantly, the promised herbal notes are largely muted. The residual oil from the batter dominates, dulling the freshness that the tartare so carefully establishes.



The next dish marks a new addition to my exploration of the menu. Despite its understated presentation, it proves to be the most compelling course of the evening. Each demi-lune pasta encloses a whole bay scallop. Smaller and naturally sweeter than their sea scallop counterparts, bay scallops lend themselves well to pasta, their tenderness complementing the delicate structure of the dough. The pasta itself is also exceptional, cooked to a precise al dente. More striking still is the sauce: a black truffle and chive beurre blanc. No one can resist the mesmerizing aroma of black truffle, but the chef doesn't just use it as a panacea. Chives are thoughtfully incorporated, introducing a fresh, verdant counterpoint that deepens rather than merely amplifying the truffle's presence. The beurre blanc, silken and restrained, carries a refinement more commonly associated with French technique than Italian rusticity. In doing so, the dish achieves a seamless dialogue between the two traditions, elevating the pasta beyond comfort and into something quietly sophisticated.



The pithivier, for which I arrive with considerable expectations, ultimately proves underwhelming. The shortcoming lies in the filling. A few slices of portobello rest at the base, while a thick layer of duxelles occupies most of the interior. In a classic duck pithivier, or even in a properly executed beef Wellington, the duxelles functions as a supporting layer, coating the protein rather than overwhelming it. Here, however, the duxelles assumes the dominant role. One cannot help but think of Hong Kong chef David Lai's mushroom Wellington, in which porcini is presented as a substantial, intact centerpiece — an approach that offers both structure and gravitas. Camphor's version feels comparatively diffuse. More problematic still is the seasoning. The duxelles lacks sufficient salinity, leaving the pastry dependent on sauce for balance. We request an additional serving, only then finding the flavors adequately aligned.



A greater disappointment arrives with the chicken dish. I retain a vivid memory of the version served three years ago, similarly presented but finished with a Marsala sauce. Now, perhaps following Chef Lijo's secret departure, the sauce has been replaced with an agrodolce, a sweet-and-sour sauce. The texture presents the first concern; the meat no longer achieves the tenderness I recall, raising legitimate questions about the justification for its \$67 price point. Structurally, the composition also feels flatter. The earlier iteration featured a delicate layer of chicken mousse that introduced nuance and dimension; that finesse is what's missing here, leaving the dish comparatively homogeneous. More puzzling is the brioche provided to absorb the sauce, as the pairing proves discordant. The sweetness and acidity of the agrodolce clash with the buttery richness of the bread, producing a combination that feels rather nauseating.

To accompany the main courses, we order a side of steamed asparagus with béarnaise sauce. The preparation is sound in principle, though the precision of the steaming could be more exacting. The natural vibrancy of the vegetable yields too readily to softness, diminishing the snap that gives asparagus its character. The selection of asparagus itself is actually commendable. Even without peeling, the stalks reveal little to no fibrous resistance. A slightly shorter steaming time would likely restore the desired tension. As for the béarnaise, it feels somewhat thick in texture. I find myself keep wondering whether a traditionally trained French master chef would consider it properly balanced, if served alongside fish.





Before deciding on dessert, I consider other options. The marzipan appears closer to shaved ice than expected, and the bread pudding seems somewhat anticlimactic. I eventually return, once again, to the kiwi. Presented at the table is a frozen disc of green apple and lemon balm tea, whose kiwi-like exterior is achieved with charcoal powder and coconut milk. The disc is designed to be cracked with a spoon, revealing the heart of the dessert: mint ice cream surrounded by kiwi cubes poached in cardamom syrup and then some kiwi jelly cubes. The composition reads more as a palate cleanser than a traditional dessert. Yet, given Los Angeles's heat, it functions as a legitimate conclusion. The inspiration draws from the chef's Southeast Asian childhood, where fruit and shaved ice form the backbone of everyday sweets. The overall tone is intentionally simple, though the layering of flavor and texture reveals a thoughtful intricacy beneath its restraint.



At the conclusion of the meal, a small pinch bowl holding two miniature madeleines is presented. There is always room for one more sweet bite, the manager says. It is a gracious gesture and a classic French touch, yet the execution feels restrained. Compared with the version served at Daniel in New York, where the madeleines may be smaller in size but not diminished in flavor or character, these feel more symbolic than memorable.

Celebrating our fourth mensiversary, the restaurant thoughtfully prepares a greeting card for us. At the neighboring table, a birthday is marked with a single candle. The gesture feels restrained, emblematic of a broader industry shift toward minimal celebration. Personally, I find such pared-down celebrations somewhat anticlimactic, if symbolism replaces substance, the effect can feel perfunctory. That said, this approach is hardly unique to Camphor. Even the three-Michelin-starred Addison adopts a similarly understated practice, which suggests that the standard has quietly shifted across tiers of dining. Service throughout the evening reflects a comparable restraint. The staff execute their duties without the finesse one might associate with fine dining. In that respect, Camphor ultimately is more of an elevated bistro — capable, but calibrated to a different ambition.

